

Escaping

You can escape:

- Special characters using the backslash (\). To escape the backslash character, use double backslashes (\\).
- Literal text strings by wrapping them in single quotation marks (' '). Bash will not perform any expansions or substitutions. The single-quoted string should not have any more single-quotation marks. Bash will not perform any backslash-escaping either.
- Literal text strings by wrapping them in double-quotation marks (" ") but allowing for
 - \$-prefixed variables, expansions and substitutions
 - backslash-escaped characters
 - backquoted (` `) command strings
 - history-expansion characters

```
# Displays Hello World
a=World; echo "Hello $a"
# Displays Hello $a
a=World; echo 'Hello $a'
# Displays Hello 'World'
a=World; echo "Hello '$a'"
```

Printer's error

The Bash Reference Manual or even this article may use wrong characters for the quotation marks. The *apostrophe* or `u+0027` used in single-quoted strings may be replaced with the *right single quotation mark* or `u+2019`. The *grave accent* or `u+0060` used in back quoted strings may be replaced with a left *single quotation mark* or `u+2018`. The *quotation mark* or `u+0022` used

in double-quoted strings may also be replaced with left and right double quotation marks. They look similar but will result in an error if used in a shell script or in the command line.

I write my books and articles in CommonMark (Markdown) and output them as HTML, ODT and PDF documents. These documents will not have such errors. When someone edits the document (before it goes to print) in a rich-text editor such as LibreOffice or Microsoft Office, the editor's autocorrect feature may change ordinary quotation marks and backquotes with inverted quotation marks. Just be aware that this can happen. To avoid mistakes, type the commands by hand. Do not copy-paste them.

Summary

I am sure you will also conclude that bash code can be very cryptic. A lot of production code (industrial-strength shell scripts) is hundreds of lines long. If bash was not so succinct and powerful, it would take forever to write the lines. If you are doing any kind of serious shell scripting, then it is best you know all about bash's myriad secrets. I think I have covered enough of them to kindle your interest. You are on your own now.

You will find all this and more in my book 'Linux Command Line Tips & Tricks'. It is free for download from most popular ebook stores. 

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The author has written over two dozen books including, *Linux Command-Line Tips & Tricks*, *CommonMark Ready Reference*, *Cool Electronic Projects* and *How To Install Solar*.

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May 2022	DevOps Special
June 2022	AI, Deep learning and Machine Learning
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August 2022	Cloud Special: Everything from management to implementation
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October 2022	Blockchain and Open Source
November 2022	Open Source and IoT and Edge
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